Galatians

Called by grace · Free to tell the truth · Session 2

FROM LAST TIME

Last time we heard Galatians 1:1–9. Jesus gave himself for our sins to rescue us. Paul is alarmed because the churches are turning toward a different gospel. Adding a requirement as the basis of acceptance before God distorts the gospel of Christ. We continue in that same letter.

READ TOGETHER — GALATIANS 1:10–24 CSB

10 For am I now trying to persuade people, or God? Or am I striving to please people? If I were still trying to please
people, I would not be a servant of Christ.

11 For I want you to know, brothers and sisters, that the gospel preached by me is not of human origin. 12 For I did
not receive it from a human source and I was not taught it, but it came by a revelation of Jesus Christ.

13 For you have heard about my former way of life in Judaism: I intensely persecuted God's church and tried to
destroy it. 14 I advanced in Judaism beyond many contemporaries among my people, because I was extremely
zealous for the traditions of my ancestors. 15 But when God, who from my mother's womb set me apart and
called me by his grace, was pleased 16 to reveal his Son in me, so that I could preach him among the Gentiles, I
did not immediately consult with anyone. 17 I did not go up to Jerusalem to those who had become apostles
before me; instead I went to Arabia and came back to Damascus.

18 Then after three years I did go up to Jerusalem to get to know Cephas, and I stayed with him fifteen days. 19
But I didn't see any of the other apostles except James, the Lord's brother. 20 I declare in the sight of God: I am
not lying in what I write to you.

21 Afterward, I went to the regions of Syria and Cilicia. 22 I remained personally unknown to the Judean churches
that are in Christ. 23 They simply kept hearing, "He who formerly persecuted us now preaches the faith he once
tried to destroy." 24 And they glorified God because of me.

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A Servant of Christ

Part 1 · Galatians 1:10–14

THE GOSPEL DOES NOT COME FROM APPROVAL

Paul has just said that even he stands under the gospel. He now answers the suspicion that his message was shaped to win people over. He asks whether he is trying to persuade people or God, and whether he is still striving to please people. A servant of Christ cannot make human approval the aim of his message.

The gospel he preaches is not of human origin. He did not receive it by trimming it to suit his hearers, and he was not taught it as his own invention. It came by a revelation of Jesus Christ. That is Paul's apostolic witness. We do not wait for a private revelation of our own. We receive this gospel in the apostolic Scriptures.

Then Paul tells what his former zeal produced. He persecuted God's church and tried to destroy it. He advanced beyond many of his contemporaries and was extremely zealous for the traditions of his ancestors. Jewish identity is not the enemy, and God's law is not a mistake. The point is sharper: impressive religious effort can still be aimed against the grace of Christ.

A man can learn to measure himself by who is impressed — the room that finds him competent, certain, and hard to need. That pressure can sand down what we say about Jesus, or keep us from admitting where we are weak. Serving Christ frees us to tell the truth. Our confidence stays in the gospel God has given, rather than in the approval we can gather.

DISCUSS

1. In 1:10–12, what is Paul refusing to live for, and where does he say his gospel came from?
2. Where does wanting to be seen as competent, certain, or hard to need make it difficult to tell the truth about Christ or about yourself?

NOTES AND REFLECTION

Called by Grace

Part 2 · Galatians 1:15–24

GOD RECEIVES THE GLORY

The story turns on God's action. God set Paul apart, called him by his grace, and was pleased to reveal his Son in him, so that he would preach Christ among the Gentiles. Paul's advancement did not earn this call. Grace reached him.

He did not immediately consult with anyone or go up to the apostles in Jerusalem. He went to Arabia and returned to Damascus. Three years later he spent fifteen days with Cephas and also saw James. He speaks with an oath because the churches need to know that his gospel came from Christ, not from a campaign to please Jerusalem or the Gentile churches. This is not a pattern of avoiding other believers. The next chapter will show him relating his gospel to the other apostles. The point here is the source.

The Judean churches did not know him by face. They kept hearing that the man who had persecuted them now preaches the faith he once tried to destroy. And they glorified God because of him. A changed life becomes a reason to worship God, rather than a reputation Paul gets to manage.

Some of us would rather edit the past, or present a record that needs no mercy. Grace gives another way. We can tell the truth about what we were and what Christ has done, and let the glory go to God. Ask a brother to help you do that without turning the story into another performance.

DISCUSS

1. What does Paul attribute to God in 1:15–16, and what do the churches do with his story in 1:23–24?
2. Where are you tempted to trust a religious record, or to hide a past, instead of letting God receive the glory for his grace? What is one true thing you could tell a brother?

PRACTICE THIS WEEK

Reread Galatians 1:10–24. When you notice yourself shaping what you say so that someone will be impressed, return to the God who called Paul by grace. Tell one brother something true about your need or about Christ's mercy, and ask him to pray. Honesty grows from grace. It does not earn acceptance.

PRAY

Father, thank you for calling us by grace and for revealing your Son. Free us from living to impress one another. Where our zeal has been aimed at the wrong glory, turn us back to Christ. Teach us to tell the truth and to give you the praise for every change you work. Amen.